

are most prevalent in the agenda of every organisation's board: AI, ESG, and cyber. While some of them are still in the early stages and taking a more measured approach, more progressive companies are well ahead on their AI journey.

Q: Do you see original work happening in the country in the AI space?

A: In terms of tech innovation, Silicon Valley has been the flagbearer (even though a lot of those initiatives were driven by Indians). But that is now changing. As I alluded to earlier, the India Stack was created locally, [as were] GSTN (the Goods and Services Tax Network) and digital payments... I don't see why you will not see an Indian company come up with new, paradigm-changing technology or products. While currently a lot of work on AI is being done in the West, Indian companies are also trying to build large language models. I see India at the forefront of innovation leveraging these technologies for use cases and products.

Q: What is Deloitte doing in this space to better serve its clients?

114 | A: Deloitte has built AI Centres of Excellence in three to four countries across the world, and India is where we build prototypes... solutions around scale, practical deployment and on solving the most critical issues using AI. We have moved away from the thought process that as Deloitte, we can solve every problem in the world. Instead, we are now making an impact by creating an ecosystem, from students to start-ups, to academia, and are working with partners like Google, Meta, SAP, Oracle, and AWS (Amazon Web Services). We are bringing it all together at these centres where people can collaborate and solve problems.

Q: Is AI a business opportunity for Indian companies to serve global markets?

A: There are two parts to it: using AI to help clients with better customer reach, product design, and automation, which equals a 30-35% benefit, and secondly increasing efficiency by at least 30%. To be honest, nobody can yet say with authority what all is possible [using AI]. But clients are looking at those aspects to say, how can I be more productive? Productivity is on top of the minds of all CEOs, including in India.

Q: Some 20 years ago, the sunrise sectors included technology, media, and telecom, among others. What will be the big upcoming sectors in India?

A: I believe that the space sector is poised to become

"The next round of growth and transformation will come from AI infused in different aspects of business and industry... our focus [is also on] digital and cloud... firms are moving to the cloud for not just cost efficiency, but also to enable a change in business models"

one of the largest in terms of value, although the growth won't happen overnight, and could take five to 10 years. [Then,] semiconductors are essential components in virtually every electronic device, and as global connectivity expands beyond the current 4%, the demand for these chips will soar, driving significant value in the industry. The manufacturing sector, particularly in electronics, also presents a substantial opportunity. Many countries rely heavily on imports for electronics, but if we can start manufacturing a lot more in India, the potential for growth is immense. The services sector will continue to play a critical role in generating high-quality employment opportunities for the country.

Q: Is it correct that you don't have an HR position?

A: We have a position called Chief Happiness Officer, along with a Chief People and Experience Officer. I prefer engaging with talent issues with 'heart' and do not ascribe to the term 'HR' for people.

Happiness isn't just about feeling good; it's about physical health, mental well-being, and embracing diversity, in various aspects like gender and financial background. For example, we have a programme called 'Heartland' where, as Deloitte, we hire from Tier III, IV [locations] and make opportunities available to young, talented people who may not have

